school in India, primarily in the hill stations of Darjeeling and Kalimpong, but also at the prestigious Doon School in Dehra Dun. One of them was Jigme Palden Dorji of the Dorji family. His younger sister, Ashi Kesang, was married to the third druk gyalpo, Jigme Dorje Wangchuk. So, he was also considered a member of the ruling Wangchuk family.

Jigme Palden Dorji was appointed gongzim in 1952 and, when the title of lonchen was introduced six years later, he became the first to hold that title. He served as prime minister during the 1962 conflict with China and, according to his close friend Nari Rustomji, his most anxious concern at that time was that the Chinese would abduct the latest reincarnation of the shabdrung, then a boy of six residing in a monastery in the Tawang area of NEFA and use him as a puppet to challenge the authority of the druk gyalpo of Bhutan. Jigme Palden Dorji, remaining loyal to the king, told Rustomji that 'the institution of Dharma Raja [shabdrung] as dead as the dodo … and if any young lad was luckless enough to be identified as a potential Dharma Raja, the Bhutanese were adept in fixing an "accident" to hurry him to his Nirvana'.[31]

Rustomji, who was then adviser to the NEFA governor, received urgent appeals from Jigme Palden Dorji to locate the young shabdrung. He was found and brought to Shillong before the Chinese occupied Tawang. The boy was then sent to the Tibetan settlement in McLeodganj to study, where he would be safe under the tutelage of the Dalai Lama. It was never clear whether Jigme Palden Dorji's fears about a Chinese abduction of the shabdrung were real or just something he suspected, and therefore wanted to take precautionary measures against.

In Bhutan, Jigme Palden Dorji was determined to modernize the country, something which the third druk gyalpo was not necessarily opposed to. But he managed to antagonize elements within the clergy by attempting to reduce the power of state-supported religious institutions. As the druk gyalpo grew older, frictions between him and his dynamic prime minister became evident. Jigme Palden Dorji also made enemies within the military over the use of some military vehicles and the forced retirement of about 50 army officers.

All those who opposed modernization, especially the traditionalists, saw an opportunity in the growing conflict between the druk gyalpo and the Dorjis. On 5 April 1964, while the druk gyalpo was undergoing medical treatment in Switzerland, Jigme Palden Dorji was assassinated at